

The metaverse, 29 years after its conceptualisation

A lot of the advanced technology we see in reality today was once the realm of fiction. Neal Stephenson coined the term metaverse in his 1992 book *Snow Crash*. He described it as a parallel digital world where humans interact with each other in *avatar* form. Almost three decades later, venture capitalist Matthew Ball describes the metaverse as a massively-scaled and interoperable network of real-time rendered three-dimensional (3D) virtual worlds, which can be experienced synchronously and persistently by an effectively unlimited number of users.

That answers all of you who are asking how the metaverse is different from the massively multi-player online (MMO) games, which are so popular today. The multiverse is not one virtual world—rather, it is a universe that brings together multiple virtual worlds. Over time, the virtual worlds will be connected and people will be able to go from world to world, carrying with them their things and money. Basically, their activities will not be tied to one world, but be spread across multiple platforms in the metaverse. That is the broad picture—although it is going to take time to get there.

Not just that, the metaverse will also be a realm that blends real and digital worlds. For example, you will be mingling with real people, and making real money on the metaverse. It is not an entirely fictional world or a game. Satya Nadella, CEO of

For the love of the game

Filipinos loved to play Axie Infinity. So, they earned Smooth Love Potions (SLP) and Axie Infinity Shards (AXS) by winning battles against zombies! They converted these crypto-tokens into ETH and subsequently to US\$ and found that this was more than what some of them were earning in real-world jobs, especially during the covid lockdowns. So, many of them gave up their real jobs to earn money playing their favourite game!

Opportunities for All

The metaverse means opportunities galore, for contributors from various fields. If there is another universe evolving, it means more demand for goods and services, so more jobs are created too.

Here is a small sample:

Chipmakers. Huge amounts of data and heavy processing obviously means huge demand for semiconductors. Likewise, the heavy use of ultrasonic and infrared sensors, force and strain sensing, and motion sensing in VR headsets creates a demand for micro-electro-mechanical systems (MEMS).

Developers. A few months ago, Mark Zuckerberg said Meta would create 10,000 jobs in Europe over five years to make a metaverse. Developers can use the software development kits (SDKs) available for various platforms to build immersive applications for the metaverse.

Designers. When we talk about creating virtual spaces, it obviously requires designers to do the job. In fact, people buying plots on virtual worlds and building houses in them are sometimes engaging real-life architects to do the job. And there is a lot of scope for creativity here, because what you build can defy all the laws of physics!

Creators. Creators of anything digital can sell their wares in the virtual worlds and make real money out of it. The biggest example is Beeple, a digital artist who had erstwhile not sold a single print for over US\$10, being able to sell an NFT for nearly US\$70 million!

Microsoft, nailed it when he said the idea is to embed computing into the real world and to embed the real world into computing, bringing real presence to any digital space.

Dissecting the definitions

As we cut through the jargon, you will see that the metaverse is actually made up of several components—virtual worlds, virtual reality gear, digital currency, etc. This will also help you understand the spate of acquisitions going on in this space, as the tech majors like Meta and Microsoft try to bring together the different cogs that make the metaverse run.

“The metaverse is a concept of virtual collaboration where people join shared three-dimensional (3D) environments as *avatars*, where they can talk, teach, learn, work, play and can also transact using blockchain tokens. Overall, it is a combination of 3D collaboration platforms, blockchain, non-fungible tokens (NFT), crypto-currency and gamification,” explains Pushpak Kypuram, Founder-Director, NextMeet, a Hyderabad based startup that has developed an immersive metaverse platform for meetups.

The metaverse is made up of virtual worlds

The metaverse, as we said, is made up of several virtual worlds, many

of which are evolved gaming platforms. Second Life, for example, was launched in 2003. Although it seems like a game from the outside, its ‘residents’ take it quite seriously—it is their chance at a second life, where the first one has not met their expectations. It feels like being in a real world, where the residents explore, meet other residents, socialise, build, create, shop, and trade virtual property and services with one another.

Way back in 2008, a couple even married each other on Second Life. They later met each other in the real world, and, thankfully hit it off. But it can also be the other way round; with couples getting divorced due to affairs in the virtual world.

Not all virtual worlds are, like, complete worlds. Some of them focus on some activities alone. For example, in World of Warcraft, Fortnite, Call of Duty, or Axie Infinity, you battle with villains to save the world. In Farmville, you focus on developing an awesome and profitable farm. In The Sandbox, you play God’s assistant, exploring and bringing together resources like water, soil, humans, wildlife, and machines to create stuff.

If you are tired of superhuman environments, then maybe you can go for the LokaLocal, a virtual world based on 3D maps of real-world